

Leave Policy - Decoding Data Science

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Internal - Synthetic demo document for AI training purposes. Not legal advice.

This policy defines all leave entitlements at DDS, how leave accrues, how to request it, and how requests are approved. It replaces Leave Policy v1 (March 2026) in full. Where UAE Federal Decree-Law No. 33 of 2021 (the UAE Labour Law) provides a greater benefit, the law prevails. Note: this is a synthetic, training-friendly policy created for demos, onboarding simulations, and HR-chatbot prototypes. It is not legal advice.

1. Leave Entitlements at a Glance

Annual leave: 22 working days per year, full pay, 7 calendar days minimum notice (see section 3.4), no evidence required. Sick leave: 15 working days per year at full pay (then per section 4.4), notify same day within 1 hour of start time, medical certificate required for 2+ consecutive days. Maternity leave: 60 calendar days, full pay, 30 calendar days' notice before expected date, medical documentation required. Paternity leave: 5 working days within 6 months of birth, full pay, 30 calendar days' notice where foreseeable, birth certificate required. Parental leave (additional): 5 working days per parent within 6 months of birth, full pay, 14 calendar days' notice, birth certificate required. Bereavement leave: 5 working days (spouse/child/parent) or 3 working days (sibling/grandparent), full pay, notify as soon as possible, documentation may be requested. Marriage leave: 3 working days (once during employment), full pay, 14 calendar days' notice, marriage certificate required. Study leave: 10 working days per year (2+ years of service, enrolled at an accredited UAE institution), full pay, 14 calendar days' notice, exam schedule/enrollment proof required. Hajj leave: up to 30 calendar days (once during employment), unpaid, 60 calendar days' notice, no evidence required. Unpaid leave: up to 30 calendar days per year, case-by-case, unpaid, 30 calendar days' notice, manager and HR approval required. Public holidays: per the official UAE calendar, full pay, not deducted from annual leave.

2. Definitions

Leave year: 1 January to 31 December. Working day: Monday to Friday, excluding UAE public holidays. Calendar day: any day, including weekends and public holidays. Immediate family: spouse, child, or parent. Leave system: the DDS HR portal where all leave is requested, approved, and tracked.

3. Annual Leave

3.1 Entitlement Full-time employees are entitled to 22 working days of paid annual leave per leave year. Part-time employees receive a pro-rata entitlement based on contracted hours. Employees who join or leave mid-year receive a pro-rata entitlement for that year.

3.2 Accrual Annual leave accrues at 1.83 working days per completed calendar month of service. During the probation period, leave accrues normally; accrued days may be used during probation with line-manager approval.

3.3 Booking limits

- The maximum single block of annual leave is 15 consecutive working days. Longer blocks require CEO approval.
- At least 5 of the 22 days must be taken as one continuous block of 5 working days each year, to support genuine rest.
- Leave may be taken in half-day units at minimum.

3.4 Notice periods for annual leave requests 1-2 working days requested: 7 calendar days' notice. 3-9 working days requested: 14 calendar days' notice. 10 or more working days requested: 30 calendar days' notice. Managers respond to leave requests within 3 business days. Employees should not book non-refundable travel before approval is confirmed in the leave system.

3.5 Peak periods During flagship delivery windows (major bootcamps, the annual conference season, and product launches), approvals may be restricted. HR publishes restricted weeks at the start of each quarter. Requests in restricted weeks require Head-of-Department approval.

4. Carry-Over, Expiry and Encashment

4.1 Carry-over A maximum of 10 unused annual-leave days may be carried into the next leave year. Carry-over is automatic; no approval is needed.

4.2 Expiry Carried-over days must be used by 31 March (end of Q1) of the new leave year. Any carried-over days not used by 31 March expire without compensation.

4.3 Encashment Unused annual leave is not paid out during employment. On termination of employment, accrued but unused annual leave for the current year is paid out at the employee's basic salary rate, in line with UAE Labour Law.

5. Sick Leave

5.1 Entitlement Employees receive 15 working days of fully paid sick leave per leave year, available after completion of the probation period.

5.2 Notification

- Notify your line manager within 1 hour of your normal start time on the first day of absence (message or call).
- Log the absence in the leave system on the day of return, or earlier if able.

5.3 Medical certificates A medical certificate from a licensed practitioner is required for any absence of 2 or more consecutive working days, and may be requested for shorter or repeated absences where a pattern suggests misuse.

5.4 Extended illness If an illness continues beyond the 15 fully paid days, additional sick leave follows the UAE Labour Law structure within the same leave year: up to 30 further calendar days at half pay, then up to 45 further calendar days unpaid, subject to medical documentation. HR manages extended-illness cases confidentially with the employee.

5.5 Partial working If an employee is unwell but able to work reduced hours, this may be agreed with the line manager. Health always takes priority; nobody is expected to work while genuinely unwell.

6. Public Holidays

- DDS observes the official UAE public-holiday calendar for Dubai-based employees. HR publishes the calendar each January.
- Public holidays are paid and are not deducted from the annual-leave balance.
- If a public holiday falls within an approved period of annual leave, that day is not counted as an annual-leave day.
- Employees contracted outside the UAE observe the public holidays of their contract location.
- Where business-critical operations (live events, launches) require work on a public holiday, the employee receives a substitute day off in lieu, to be taken within 60 days.

7. Maternity, Paternity and Parental Leave

7.1 Maternity leave

- 60 calendar days at full pay. This exceeds the UAE statutory minimum as an enhanced DDS benefit.
- Notify HR at least 30 calendar days before the expected date of leave, with medical documentation.
- Leave may begin up to 30 days before the expected delivery date.

- An additional period of up to 45 calendar days unpaid may be taken for medical reasons related to the pregnancy or delivery, with a medical certificate.

7.2 Nursing breaks For 6 months following return from maternity leave, the employee is entitled to one paid nursing break of 1 hour per day, scheduled flexibly with the line manager.

7.3 Paternity leave Fathers receive 5 working days at full pay, to be taken within 6 months of the child's birth, consecutively or split. Provide notice 30 calendar days ahead where foreseeable.

7.4 Parental leave (additional) In addition to maternity/paternity leave, each parent may take 5 working days of paid parental leave within 6 months of the birth, in line with UAE Labour Law.

7.5 Adoption Employees adopting a child under the age of 5 receive the same entitlements as in sections 7.1-7.4, measured from the date of placement.

7.6 Return to work Managers must agree a written transition plan before leave begins and a re-onboarding plan for the return. Returning parents come back to the same role or an equivalent role on the same terms.

8. Other Leave Types

8.1 Bereavement (compassionate) leave 5 working days at full pay for the death of a spouse, child, or parent; 3 working days at full pay for the death of a sibling, grandparent, or grandchild. Notify your manager as soon as possible; documentation may be requested. Additional unpaid leave may be approved case-by-case.

8.2 Marriage leave 3 working days at full pay, once during employment, taken within 30 days of the marriage. Provide 14 calendar days' notice and a marriage certificate.

8.3 Study and exam leave Employees with 2 or more years of service who are enrolled at an accredited UAE educational institution receive 10 working days of paid study leave per year for examinations, per UAE Labour Law. Provide the exam schedule 14 calendar days ahead.

8.4 Hajj leave Muslim employees may take up to 30 calendar days of unpaid leave once during their employment to perform Hajj. Request 60 calendar days in advance so coverage can be planned.

8.5 Unpaid leave

- Up to 30 calendar days per leave year, approved case-by-case by the line manager and HR.
- Annual leave must be exhausted first unless HR agrees otherwise.
- Unpaid leave may affect payroll, benefits accrual, and visa arrangements; HR will confirm the impact in writing before approval.

9. Religious Observance and Ramadan Working Hours

- During Ramadan, daily working hours are reduced by 2 hours for all employees, per UAE regulation.
- Teams schedule meetings considerably around fasting and prayer times.
- Additional flexibility (shifted hours, remote days) can be agreed with the line manager where the role allows.

10. How to Request Leave (Workflow)

Step 1: Employee submits the request in the leave system with dates, leave type, and a short coverage plan (deliverables, who covers, key deadlines), per the notice table in section 3.4. Step 2: Line manager reviews and approves/declines with a reason, within 3 business days. Step 3: HR runs an automatic compliance check for balance, carry-over expiry, and restricted weeks. Step 4: Employee notifies affected stakeholders and hands over client-facing commitments before leave starts. Step 5: For emergency leave, the employee notifies their manager immediately by any channel, then submits the request retroactively within 48 hours. Approved leave appears in the shared team calendar. Cancelling approved leave restores the days to the employee's balance automatically.

11. Misuse and Compliance

- Misrepresenting sickness, falsifying certificates, or working a second job while on sick leave are treated as misconduct under the DDS Disciplinary Policy.
- DDS may request documentation where reasonable and lawful.
- Managers may not pressure employees to cancel or shorten approved leave except in genuine business emergencies, and any such case must be reported to HR.

12. Governance

- Policy owner: Head of People & Culture, DDS.
- Review cycle: annually, each June, or earlier if UAE labour regulations change.
- Precedence: where an employment contract or UAE Labour Law grants a greater benefit, that provision prevails over this policy.
- Questions: contact People & Culture via the HR portal, or ask DecoBot, the DDS HR assistant.

Version history: v1.0 (March 2026) initial synthetic policy. v2.0 (July 2026) full rewrite with fixed entitlements, notice tables, carry-over and expiry rules, extended parental provisions, and workflow SLAs.